Saryarqa Go

ZERTTEX Hackathon 2026, Stage 1. Case 1: Technology Product
Team: _____

1. Summary

Saryarqa Routes is a tour company from Astana. In 2025 it had 3,400 travelers, but about 96% of them were from Kazakhstan, and the company wants 30% of its travelers to come from abroad within 24 months (case data). We think the main reason foreigners do not book is simple: they cannot easily see what a trip includes, they cannot pay with their own card, and they have no way to check that the company is real.

Our answer is Saryarqa Go, a booking website and app in English and Chinese. We start with independent travelers from China. The first version can be built in 12 weeks within the 20 million KZT budget from the case. With our assumptions it pays back in month 32, or in month 44 if we get 30% fewer travelers than planned.

2. The problem

Today the company sells tours through Instagram messages, WhatsApp and phone calls. Customers pay by Kaspi transfer or cash, and the website is one page in Russian (case data). This works for local customers, but not for a tourist from Shanghai or Berlin. The case lists four things foreign guests said, and each of them stops a booking before the payment:

What guests said (case data)	**When the booking fails**	**Why it happens now**
"It is unclear how to book."	Before the first message	Sales only through chats; Russian-only website
"I am not sure the company is trustworthy."	Before sending money abroad	Nothing on the website proves the company is real
"My foreign card does not work."	At the payment	Only Kaspi transfer or cash
"I do not know what is included."	Before deciding	No clear list of what the price covers

3. Why we start with travelers from China

According to the Ministry of Tourism and Sports, about 655,000 people from China visited Kazakhstan in 2024, 78% more than in 2023 [1][2]. Since November 2023 the two countries have a visa-free regime: up to 30 days per visit and up to 90 days in any 180 days [1]. In 2024 China was the largest source of tourists outside the neighbouring countries [3]. Overall Kazakhstan counted 15.3 million foreign visitors for tourism in 2024 [3], and 15.7 million in the first nine months of 2025 alone [5].

We are careful with these numbers. An analyst estimate gives 241,700 Chinese visitors in 2025 [4], which is much lower than the Ministry figure for 2024, but the two are counted in different ways, so we do not compare them. World Bank data [6] only counts overnight arrivals, which is again a different definition.

Because there is no visa barrier, the decision for a Chinese traveler mostly depends on trust, clear information and payment, which are exactly the four complaints above. The tours also fit what independent travelers look for: nature and photography (Charyn, Kolsai, Burabay) and Silk Road history (Turkestan). This last point is our own judgement, not a statistic.

How many more foreign travelers are needed

About 4% of 3,400 travelers are foreign today, so roughly 136 people. If the company keeps its 3,264 local travelers, foreigners have to be 30% of about 4,663 travelers in total, which is about 1,399 people. That means around 1,263 additional foreign travelers per year, or about 105 per month. Fixing only one complaint will not be enough to get there.

4. Our solution: Saryarqa Go

Saryarqa Go covers the whole trip, not only the booking form. We built it around six steps. The last step (sharing a postcard) brings the next traveler back to the first one.

Step	**What the traveler gets**	**Which complaint it solves**
Discover	Tour pages in English and Chinese. Each tour shows four lists: included, optional extras, not included, and not yet confirmed.	"I do not know what is included"
Plan	A trip builder that puts tours, transfers between Almaty, Turkestan and Astana, and free days into the number of days the traveler has.	"It is unclear how to book"
Check	A trust page with a short video from the guide, a 5-minute video call before paying, refund rules and an honest list of what is verified. A chat in English and Chinese that passes hard questions to a manager.	"I am not sure the company is trustworthy"
Book	Booking in three steps. Payment with a foreign card on the payment provider's page. Alipay and WeChat Pay later, after the providers approve us. Prices in KZT with USD or CNY next to them.	"My foreign card does not work"
Travel	A trip page with daily check-ins, optional updates for family at home, and free rescheduling if a mountain road is closed.	Trust during the trip
Share	A postcard sized for Xiaohongshu and WeChat Moments with a link for friends.	Cheap way to find new travelers

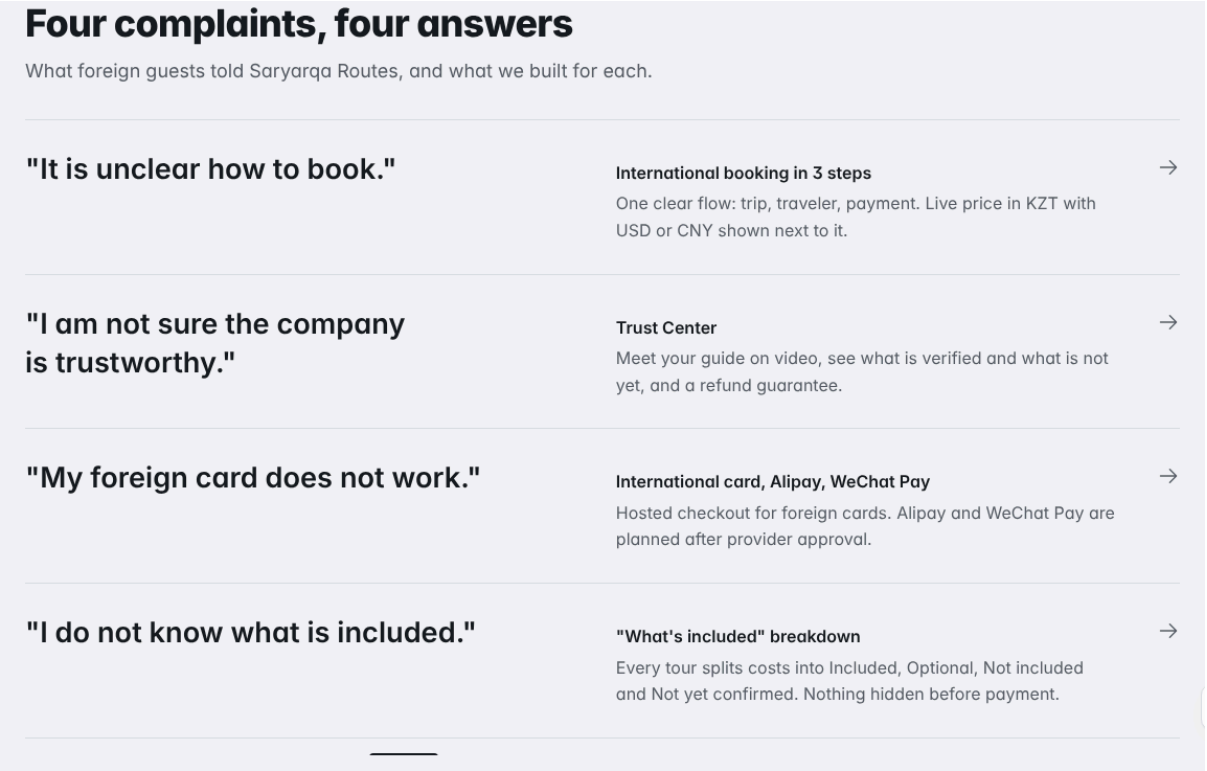


Figure 1. Our prototype: each complaint from the case is linked to a feature.

5. What makes it different

Most travel sites hide what is still unknown. We do the opposite. Park fees, exact guesthouse names, the 4x4 transfer at Kaindy and the availability of a Chinese-speaking guide are shown in a separate "not yet confirmed" list, and the company confirms them in writing before the trip. We think being open about this builds more trust than a perfect-looking page.

For someone traveling to a new country, the guide is the company. That is why the traveler can watch a short video of the guide and book a 5-minute call before paying. The chat answers in the traveler's language, but only from checked tour information. If it does not know something, for example whether there are free places on a date, it says so and passes the question to a person.

Two smaller ideas are also important for Chinese travelers and their families. Family members can follow the trip status (not the exact location) if the traveler turns it on, and it stops automatically after the trip. The postcard at the end is something people want to post anyway, so it becomes free advertising.

In the prototype every number and claim has a small label: case data, checked source, our proposal, demo data, or "needs confirmation". We did this so that judges and future customers can see what is a fact and what is still a plan.

6. A realistic 12-week MVP

Weeks	What we do	We know it is done when
1-2	Interviews and research; apply to payment providers	At least 10 interviews with Chinese travelers; applications sent
3-4	Design and tour pages in English and Chinese	4 tour pages checked by 3 or more target users
5-7	Booking, inclusion lists, chat, trust page	A full test booking works in the payment test mode
8-9	Trip builder, real payment page, rescheduling	Staff make a first real test payment
10-11	Usability tests and payment checks	5-8 test sessions with no blocking problems left
12	Pilot with real travelers	Pilot results collected

Everything that depends on another company's approval or on live data comes later: Alipay and WeChat Pay, a smarter AI chat, live weather and road data, GPS sharing, offline audio, and listing on Trip.com or Klook. This way the MVP does not get stuck waiting for someone else.

The app would be built with React and TypeScript, a database with an admin page for the managers, and the payment provider's own payment page, so card data never touches our servers. We plan a small hired team: a designer, two developers and a Chinese translator, with one person from Saryarqa Routes as the product owner (our proposal).

We already have a working clickable prototype that shows the whole path from choosing a tour to the postcard. Payments in it are only simulated and it collects no card or passport data. It was built with the help of an AI coding assistant; see our AI Declaration.

7. Costs, payback and impact

The year-1 budget is exactly 20,000,000 KZT: 12 million for building the product and 8 million for launch, marketing, support and a reserve. The company earns its normal margin on every additional foreign traveler. We assume a 30% margin on the average price of 44,000 KZT, so 13,200 KZT per traveler (our assumption). The company needs about 1,516 additional travelers in total to earn back 20 million. With our ramp-up plan the money comes back in month 32. If demand is 30% lower, it comes back in month 44. The full calculation is in the separate financial document.

If it works, the company gets a second source of income next to local customers. Travelers get clear prices, a way to pay with their own card, and a guide they have already met. For Kazakhstan, every positive trip that is shared on Chinese social media is a small advertisement for the country, and it brings tourists to regions outside Almaty and Astana.

8. Risks

Risk	What we do about it
Alipay or WeChat Pay approval takes long or is refused	Start with foreign cards on the provider's page; apply in week 1; a manager can help with payment as a backup
The chat gives a wrong answer	It only uses checked tour information, says "I don't know" when unsure and passes the question to a person; we read the chat logs every week
Not enough demand from China	Talk to travelers before building; run a small pilot; test Xiaohongshu posts and postcards before paying for ads
Data and privacy rules	Collect only what we need (no passport, no card numbers); get a legal check; family sharing is off by default
Guides do not speak enough Chinese	Test the guides; work with interpreters; show Chinese guides as "not yet confirmed" until checked; offer the audio guide in Chinese

Before launch we still need to confirm the company's registration, licence and insurance documents, the park and site fees, the payment provider's terms, and whether the 30% margin matches the company's real costs.